

There is a strange performance we've perfected in modern dating.

We are expected to care deeply while looking as though we couldn't care less.

Want someone? Be chill.

Miss them? Don't say it too quickly.

Need reassurance? Careful. You might be "needy."

Want to know where things are going? Apparently, you have just introduced pressure into an otherwise perfectly peaceful ecosystem.

Become attached? Hide the evidence.

Whatever you do, never let the other person discover that they have become important to you.

The goal seems to be to feel everything while displaying absolutely nothing.

We have somehow turned emotional detachment into a personality trait.

There are dating rules for everything now. Don't reply too quickly. Don't double text. Don't seem too available. Don't ask too many questions. Don't show too much interest. Don't let them know you are waiting for their message.

At some point, you stop dating and start managing your brand.

You are no longer a human being developing feelings for another human being.

You are a PR department.

And God forbid the campaign reveals that you actually like the product.

I have never understood this obsession with appearing unbothered.

Maybe it is because I have always believed that if someone matters to you, eventually that fact will become inconvenient.

You will notice when they are quiet.

You will care when something is wrong.

You will want to know how they are doing.

You will miss them.

You will want to talk about things that don't feel right.

You will occasionally need reassurance.

Not because you are incapable of functioning independently, but because you are emotionally involved.

That is what involvement means.

And this is where I think we have gotten ourselves into trouble.

We keep asking people to participate in intimacy while remaining emotionally detached from the consequences of that intimacy.

We want closeness without vulnerability.

Affection without expectations.

Companionship without responsibility.

We want someone who cares about us, but we don't want to be accountable for the fact that our behavior affects them.

We want to be special, but we don't want anyone asking what special actually means.

We want someone to miss us, but preferably in silence.

It is a very impressive arrangement.

It is also completely absurd.

Because you cannot ask someone to be attached and detached at the same time.

Human beings are not built with an emotional toggle switch.

There is no setting for:

Affection: On.

Intimacy: On.

Attachment: On.

Expectations: Off.

Vulnerability: Off.

Consequences: Absolutely not.

If only.

It would save us all a tremendous amount of trouble.

The reality is that closeness creates attachment.

Spend enough time with someone and they become familiar.

Learn their habits and you begin to notice when something changes.

Share enough of yourself and you become vulnerable to the person holding that information.

Let someone into your routines and their absence eventually becomes noticeable.

This isn't dysfunction.

It is attachment doing what attachment does.

Of course, attachment doesn't mean entitlement.

Caring about someone does not give you ownership over them.

Wanting reassurance does not mean another person has to spend their entire day proving their love.

Having expectations does not mean you get to dictate someone's every move.

There is a difference between expressing a need and making someone responsible for your emotional stability.

There is a difference between saying, "Communication matters to me," and demanding that someone respond within five minutes or face a full parliamentary inquiry.

There is a difference between wanting reassurance and needing constant validation.

There is a difference between having boundaries and issuing commands.

Those distinctions matter.

But I think we have become so afraid of neediness that we sometimes treat ordinary human needs as embarrassing.

Reassurance, in particular, has been given an unfair reputation.

Somehow, asking someone, "Are we okay?" has become evidence that you are insecure.

Wanting to hear, "I care about you," is apparently a sign that you don't care enough about yourself.

Admitting that you miss someone is considered giving away too much power.

Why?

When did affection become a negotiation over who has the upper hand?

I don't think reassurance is inherently needy.

Sometimes reassurance is simply kindness.

Sometimes people need to hear:

"I am here."

"We're okay."

"You matter to me."

"I still care."

That doesn't mean they have no self worth without those words.

It means relationships involve two people, and sometimes words from the person we love carry a particular weight.

We already understand this everywhere else.

We reassure children.

We comfort our friends.

We check on our parents.

We tell people we love them when they are afraid.

We remind people they aren't alone.

Yet romance enters the room and suddenly everyone is expected to have the emotional independence of a monk living on a mountain.

Please.

We are human beings.

Of course we want to know that the people we love still want us around.

That doesn't make us weak.

And perhaps the bigger problem is that we have started confusing emotional regulation with emotional suppression.

Emotional regulation means being able to feel something without allowing the feeling to dictate every action.

It means you can be anxious without sending seventeen messages.

It means you can be hurt without trying to punish someone.

It means you can miss someone without making their absence a crime.

It means you can ask for reassurance without demanding that another person become responsible for your entire emotional life.

Suppression is different.

Suppression says:

Don't admit you care.

Don't ask.

Don't say you miss them.

Don't tell them that hurt.

Don't expect anything.

Don't become attached.

Pretend you're fine.

Pretend you don't need anyone.

Pretend you could leave tomorrow and wouldn't care.

That isn't always strength.

Sometimes it is fear wearing a very convincing disguise.

And I think this is where the "be chill" philosophy starts becoming dangerous.

Because being chill sounds wonderful until you realize what it can require.

You start swallowing questions.

You stop bringing things up.

You become afraid that honesty will be interpreted as pressure.

You learn to ask for less.

Then even less.

Eventually, you become incredibly easy to be around.

Not because you have suddenly become emotionally mature.

Because you have stopped taking up emotional space.

There is a difference.

I don't want relationships where two people are constantly trying to prove how little they need each other.

I don't want love to become a competition to see who can care less.

I don't want to be admired for being "low maintenance" because I have trained myself not to have needs.

I would rather know myself honestly.

If something matters to me, I want to be able to say it.

If something hurts, I want to be able to discuss it.

If I need reassurance, I want to be able to ask.

If I am attached, I don't want to pretend I am not.

That doesn't mean everyone has to give me exactly what I want.

This is the part people sometimes forget.

Honest communication is not a demand for compliance.

I can tell someone what I need and they can tell me they cannot provide it.

They are allowed to have boundaries.

They are allowed to want something different.

They are allowed to need space.

They are allowed to say no.

And I am allowed to decide what their answer means for me.

That, to me, is far healthier than pretending neither person needs anything.

Because sometimes two people simply want different things.

One person may want closeness without commitment.

Another may want closeness that eventually develops into commitment.

One person may be comfortable with ambiguity.

Another may find ambiguity emotionally exhausting.

One person may be able to separate intimacy from attachment.

Another may not.

Neither person has to be evil.

Neither person has to be crazy.

Neither person has to be "too much."

They may simply be incompatible in what they need from the connection.

And that is a much harder truth to accept than blaming someone for being needy.

Because if someone is "too needy," there is an easy solution.

They need to become less needy.

If someone is "too detached," they need to become more available.

If someone is "too emotional," they need to calm down.

If someone "doesn't want pressure," the other person needs to stop asking questions.

Everyone gets a prescription.

Nobody has to confront the possibility that the relationship itself may not work.

But sometimes the relationship is the problem.

Not the people.

The arrangement.

The expectations.

The timing.

The mismatch.

The fact that two people can genuinely care about each other and still be unable to give each other what they need.

That is one of the saddest things about relationships.

Love doesn't automatically create compatibility.

Caring doesn't automatically create commitment.

Chemistry doesn't automatically create security.

And intimacy doesn't automatically create a future.

Sometimes you can mean a great deal to someone and still not receive the kind of love that makes you feel safe.

That doesn't make the love fake.

It means love and suitability are not the same thing.

Perhaps that is what we need to become better at accepting.

We don't have to make someone the villain because they cannot give us what we need.

We don't have to make ourselves the villain because we need more than someone can offer.

We can simply tell the truth.

This matters to me.

I care about you.

I need this.

I cannot give you that.

I want more.

I want less.

I am comfortable here.

I am not.

Those conversations are uncomfortable.

Of course they are.

Caring is inconvenient.

It makes us vulnerable.

It creates something to lose.

But maybe that is the price of allowing another person to matter.

You cannot have intimacy without vulnerability.

You cannot have attachment without the possibility of loss.

You cannot have love without giving someone the ability to affect you.

That is the bargain.

And I don't think we should be ashamed of it.

I would rather be honest about caring than spend my life trying to look unbothered.

I would rather ask for reassurance than pretend I never need it.

I would rather have the difficult conversation than slowly become resentful because I was too afraid to speak.

I would rather know that I loved openly than become very good at pretending I didn't.

Because perhaps the goal of a relationship isn't to need nothing.

Perhaps it is to find someone with whom you can be honest about what you need.

Someone who can say, "This is what I can give."

Someone else can say, "This is what I need."

And together, you find out whether there is enough space between those two truths to build something.

Sometimes there is.

Sometimes there isn't.

But I think there is dignity in knowing.

We spend so much time trying not to look foolish for caring that we forget something rather important.

Caring is not embarrassing.

Wanting reassurance is not automatically needy.

Having expectations is not automatically controlling.

Having difficult conversations is not automatically pressure.

And being attached to someone is not a failure of emotional independence.

Sometimes it simply means that someone matters.

And perhaps we should stop treating that as something that needs to be hidden.

Because I am not interested in becoming so good at pretending I don't care that even the person I love starts believing me.